



Cybersecurity & Ethical Hacking Internship Report

Organization: Ansh Infotech

Role: Cybersecurity Intern

Duration: January 2026 - Present

Focus: Linux Administration, Networking Fundamentals, Vulnerability Assessment, Social Engineering



Executive Summary

This repository documents my daily learning progress, lab setups, and practical exercises during my internship. The training spans from core Linux system administration to offensive security techniques like social engineering and network exploitation.



Phase 1: Linux Fundamentals & System Administration

Dates: Jan 15, 2026 – Jan 28, 2026

◆ Learning Modules

- 1. Linux Architecture:**
 - Explored distributions: **Kali Linux** (Offensive Security), **Ubuntu**, and **Debian**.
 - Understood the Linux File Hierarchy Structure (root /, /home, /etc, /var).
 - Desktop Environments.
- 2. Essential CLI Commands:**
 - **File Ops:** touch (create), cat (read), cp (copy), mv (move), rm (remove).
 - **Editors:** Using nano for terminal-based text editing.
 - **System Info:** uname -a (kernel info), whoami, ls -h (human-readable list).
- 3. User & Permission Management (Crucial for Security):**
 - **Permissions:** Mastered the **rwX** (Read-4, Write-2, Execute-1) system.
 - **Commands:**
 - chmod: Changing file modes (e.g., chmod +x script.sh to make executable).
 - chown: Changing file ownership.
 - sudo vs su: Superuser execution vs. switching user context.
- 4. Package & Process Management:**
 - Managed software using apt (Advanced Package Tool): update, install, purge.

- **Monitoring:** Used top and ps to track real-time system resources.

Practical Evidence

Practicing file permission commands and process monitoring.

Permission	Number
No permission	0
Execute (x)	1
Write (w)	2
Write & Execute (wx)	3
Read (r)	4
Read & Execute (rx)	5
Read & Write (rw)	6
Read, Write, & Execute (rwx)	7

Permissions	Alphabetic	Numeric	Description
---		0	No permissions.
--x		1	Execute only.
-w-		2	Write only.
-wx		3	Write and execute.
r--		4	Read only.
r-x		5	Read and execute.
rw-		6	Read and write.
rwx		7	Read, write, and execute.



Phase 2: Vulnerability Assessment & Lab Setup

Date: Jan 29, 2026

◆ Lab Configuration

Transitioned to an offensive mindset by setting up a safe, isolated environment for testing exploits.

- **Target Machine:** Metasploitable (intentionally vulnerable Linux VM).
- **Attacker Machine:** Kali Linux.

◆ Tools & Techniques

- **NMAP (Network Mapper):**
 - Used for network discovery and security auditing.
 - Scanned targets to identify open ports and services.
- **Exploitation Basics:**
 - Connected to the vulnerable lab using **FTP** and **msfconsole** (Metasploit Framework).
- **Phishing Simulation:**
 - Deployed **Zphisher** to understand credential harvesting attacks.



Practical Evidence

Setup of Metasploitable lab and initial port scanning.

```
To access official Ubuntu documentation, please visit:
http://help.ubuntu.com/
No mail.
msfadmin@metasploitable:~$ ifconfig
eth0      Link encap:Ethernet  HWaddr 00:0c:29:03:59:73
          inet addr:192.168.91.129  Bcast:192.168.91.255  Mask:255.255.255.0
          inet6 addr: fe80::20c:29ff:fe03:5973/64 Scope:Link
          UP BROADCAST RUNNING MULTICAST  MTU:1500  Metric:1
          RX packets:40 errors:0 dropped:0 overruns:0 frame:0
          TX packets:65 errors:0 dropped:0 overruns:0 carrier:0
          collisions:0 txqueuelen:1000
          RX bytes:4262 (4.1 KB)  TX bytes:6826 (6.6 KB)
          Interrupt:17 Base address:0x2000

lo        Link encap:Local Loopback
          inet addr:127.0.0.1  Mask:255.0.0.0
          inet6 addr: ::1/128 Scope:Host
          UP LOOPBACK RUNNING  MTU:16436  Metric:1
          RX packets:91 errors:0 dropped:0 overruns:0 frame:0
          TX packets:91 errors:0 dropped:0 overruns:0 carrier:0
          collisions:0 txqueuelen:0
          RX bytes:19301 (18.8 KB)  TX bytes:19301 (18.8 KB)

msfadmin@metasploitable:~$
```

```
(root@kali) ~[/home/kali]
# nmap -sV 192.168.91.129
Starting Nmap 7.98 ( https://nmap.org ) at 2026-02-06 14:23 +0530
Nmap scan report for 192.168.91.129
Host is up (0.00094s latency).
Not shown: 977 closed tcp ports (reset)
PORT      STATE SERVICE      VERSION
21/tcp    open  ftp          vsftpd 2.3.4
22/tcp    open  ssh          OpenSSH 4.7p1 Debian Subuntu1 (protocol 2.0)
23/tcp    open  telnet       Linux telnetd
25/tcp    open  smtp         Postfix smtpd
53/tcp    open  domain       ISC BIND 9.4.2
80/tcp    open  http         Apache httpd 2.2.8 ((Ubuntu) DAV/2)
111/tcp   open  rpcbind      2 (RPC #100000)
139/tcp   open  netbios-ssn  Samba smbd 3.X - 4.X (workgroup: WORKGROUP)
445/tcp   open  netbios-ssn  Samba smbd 3.X - 4.X (workgroup: WORKGROUP)
512/tcp   open  exec         netkit-rsh rexecd
513/tcp   open  login        OpenBSD or Solaris rlogind
514/tcp   open  tcpwrapped
1099/tcp  open  java-rmi     GNU Classpath grmiregistry
1524/tcp  open  bindshell    Metasploitable root shell
2049/tcp  open  nfs          2-4 (RPC #100003)
2121/tcp  open  ftp          ProFTPD 1.3.1
3306/tcp  open  mysql        MySQL 5.0.51a-3ubuntu5
5432/tcp  open  postgresql   PostgreSQL DB 8.3.0 - 8.3.7
5900/tcp  open  vnc          VNC (protocol 3.3)
6000/tcp  open  X11          (access denied)
6667/tcp  open  irc          UnrealIRCd
8009/tcp  open  ajp13        Apache Jserv (Protocol v1.3)
8180/tcp  open  http         Apache Tomcat/Coyote JSP engine 1.1
MAC Address: 00:0C:29:03:59:73 (VMware)
Service Info: Hosts: metasploitable.localdomain, irc.Metasploitable.LAN; OSs: Unix, Linux; CPE: cpe:/o:linux:linux_kernel

Service detection performed. Please report any incorrect results at https://nmap.org/submit/ .
Nmap done: 1 IP address (1 host up) scanned in 12.21 seconds
```



Phase 3: Networking Core Concepts

Dates: Jan 30, 2026 – Feb 4, 2026

◆ Theory & Architecture

A solid understanding of networking is the backbone of cybersecurity.

1. Network Topologies:

- **PAN:** Personal Area (Bluetooth/NFC).
- **LAN/WLAN:** Local Area (Home/Office Wi-Fi).
- **MAN/WAN:** Metropolitan & Wide Area (Inter-city/Internet).

2. The OSI Model (7 Layers):

- Physical, Data Link, Network, Transport, Session, Presentation, Application.
- *Key Takeaway:* Understanding where data exists (cable vs. IP packet vs. HTTP request) helps in diagnosing attacks.

3. Addressing & Protocols:

- **MAC Address:** 48-bit physical hardware address (Hexadecimal).
- **IP Address:** Logical address (IPv4 vs. IPv6).
- **Transmission Modes:** Unicast (1-to-1), Multicast (1-to-many), Broadcast (1-to-all).

4. Ports & Services Table:

- **FTP:** 20/21 (File Transfer)
- **SSH:** 22 (Secure Shell)
- **HTTP/HTTPS:** 80/443 (Web)
- **DNS:** 53 (Domain Name System)



Phase 4: Ethical Hacking - Social Engineering

Date: Feb 6, 2026

◆ Human-Centric Vulnerabilities

Started the "Ethical Hacking" module, focusing on the weakest link in security: the human element.

◆ Attack Vectors Studied

1. **Phishing:** Fraudulent communications to induce users to reveal sensitive info.
2. **Pretexting:** Fabricating scenarios (e.g., posing as HR or IT) to steal data.
3. **Baiting:** Using physical media (USB drives) or free downloads to entice victims.
4. **Tailgating/Piggybacking:** Following authorized personnel into restricted areas.
5. **Scareware:** Malicious software confusing users into visiting malware sites.

◆ Tools Used

- **Zphisher:** For automated phishing templates.
- **ALHacking:** Comprehensive hacking tool suite.



Practical Evidence

Running Zphisher for educational phishing simulation.



Phase 5: Real-World Reconnaissance & SSH Exploitation Testing

Dates: Feb 11, 2026 – Feb 12, 2026

◆ Target Analysis & Information Gathering (Feb 11)

- **Target:** gndec.ac.in (175.176.187.102)
- **Reconnaissance:** Conducted active scanning using Nmap (`nmap -sV -sC`) to map out open ports, services, and OS fingerprints.
- **Findings:** Identified legacy software running on the live target, specifically OpenSSH 7.2p2 and Apache httpd 2.4.18, indicating an older Ubuntu 16.04 server environment.

◆ Vulnerability Assessment & SSH Exploitation (Feb 12)

SSH Username Enumeration (CVE-2018-15473): * Attempted automated enumeration using Metasploit (`auxiliary/scanner/ssh/ssh_enumusers`).

- Identified that high network latency (2.2s) caused a "false positive storm" due to the

tool's integer-based threshold limitations.

Manual Timing Analysis: * Bypassed automated tool limitations by manually testing SSH response times (`time ssh`).

- Discovered an "inverted" timing pattern where valid users (e.g., `root`) responded significantly faster (0.52s) than nonexistent users (3.73s). Successfully confirmed the vulnerability with a clear ~3.2s timing delta.

SSH Brute-Force Testing: * Utilized Metasploit's `auxiliary/scanner/ssh/ssh_login` module to launch a dictionary attack against identified users.

- Monitored the server's response to high-frequency login attempts to evaluate the effectiveness of Intrusion Prevention Systems (e.g., Fail2Ban), noting the server permitted over 120 rapid sequential attempts without immediate IP blocking.



Phase 6: Mobile Application Security & Static Analysis

Date: Feb 13, 2026

◆ Mobile Security Assessment

Conducted a comprehensive Static Application Security Testing (SAST) audit on a third-party modified Android application to identify privacy violations, hardcoded secrets, and vulnerability patterns.

- **Target Application:** `InstaPro_v14.25.apk` (Modded Instagram Client)
- **Package Name:** `com.instapro.android`
- **Tool Used:** MobSF (Mobile Security Framework) v4.4.5

◆ Key Findings (Static Analysis)

Security Score:

- The application received a **Security Score of 50/100 (Grade B)**, indicating Medium Risk.

Dangerous Permissions:

- Analysis revealed excessive permission requests that pose privacy risks, including:
 - `android.permission.READ_CONTACTS` (Read user contacts)
 - `android.permission.RECORD_AUDIO` & `CAMERA` (Surveillance risk)

- `android.permission.READ_CALL_LOG` & `READ_SMS` (Sensitive communication data)
- `android.permission.ACCESS_FINE_LOCATION` (Precise GPS tracking)

Hardcoded Secrets & Information Leakage:

- **API Keys:** Found exposed `google_api_key` and Firebase configuration URLs (`firebase_database_url`) in the source code.
- **Log Leakage:** Detected source code explicitly logging sensitive information, violating OWASP MSTG-STORAGE-3.

Code Vulnerabilities:

- **Cryptographic Weakness:** Identified the use of `CBC` encryption mode with `PKCS5/PKCS7` padding, which is vulnerable to padding oracle attacks (High Severity).
- **SQL Injection:** Found raw SQL queries executing untrusted user input (CWE-89).
- **Insecure Randomness:** Use of insufficient random number generators (CWE-330).



Practical Evidence

The screenshot displays the MobSF web interface for analyzing the APK file `InstaPro_v14.25.apk`. Key sections include:

- APP SCORES:** Shows a security score of 90/100 and a trackers score of 4/432.
- FILE INFORMATION:** Lists file hashes (MD5, SHA1, SHA256) and file size (139.09MB).
- APP INFORMATION:** Provides details about the app name, package name, main activity, target SDK, min SDK, max SDK, and Android version.
- EXPORTED ACTIVITIES:** 52 / 482
- EXPORTED SERVICES:** 14 / 98
- EXPORTED RECEIVERS:** 20 / 62
- EXPORTED PROVIDERS:** 12 / 16
- SCAN OPTIONS:** Includes buttons for Rescan, Manage Suppressions, Start Dynamic Analysis, and Scan Logs.
- DECOMPILED CODE:** Offers links to view AndroidManifest.xml, View Source, View Smali, Download Java Code, Download Smali Code, and Download APK.
- SIGNER CERTIFICATE:** Displays certificate details, including the signer's name, subject, issuer, and various cryptographic hashes.

Generated a full PDF report via MobSF highlighting the security score, tracker detection (4/432), and the manifest analysis of the `InstaPro` APK.



Phase 7: Hands-on Exploitation (Hack The Box)

Date: Feb 16, 2026

◆ CTF / Lab Challenges

Started practical machine exploitation on the Hack The Box (HTB) platform to reinforce scanning and enumeration skills.

Target 1: Meow (Linux)

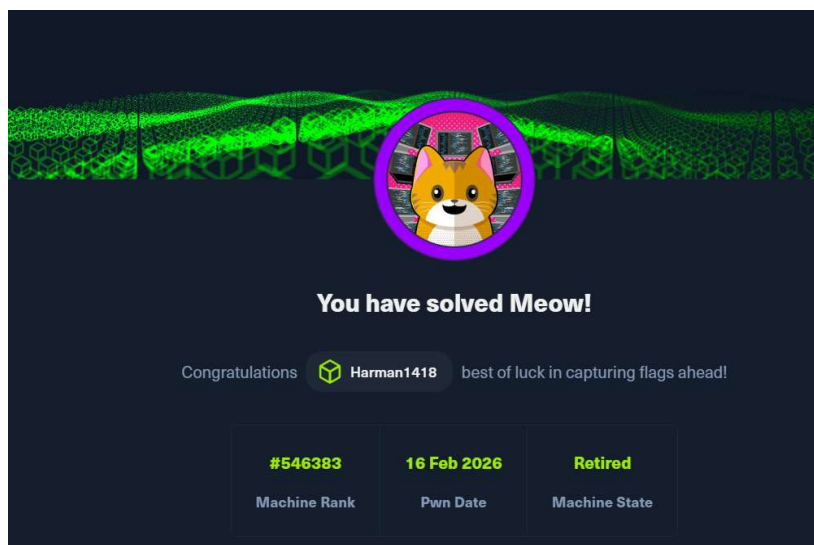
- **Difficulty:** Very Easy.
- **Objective:** Gain root access via Telnet.
- **Process:**
 - Connected via OpenVPN.
 - Scanned target using **nmap**. Identified Port 23 (Telnet) as open.
 - Attempted connection using **telnet <IP>**.
 - Exploited weak configuration by logging in as **root** with no password.
 - Retrieved the **root.txt** flag.

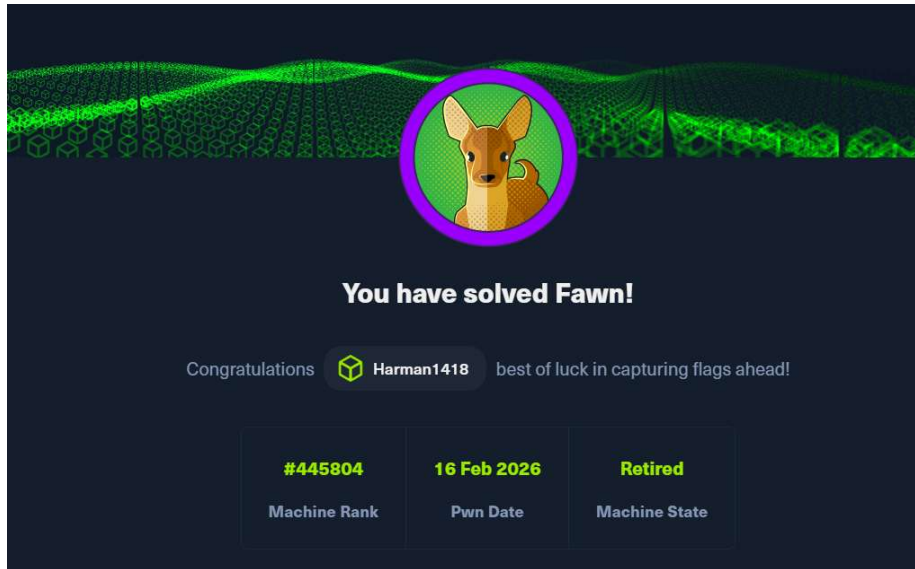
Target 2: Fawn (Linux)

- **Difficulty:** Very Easy.
- **Objective:** Data exfiltration via FTP.
- **Process:**
 - Scanned target using **nmap**. Identified Port 21 (FTP) as open.
 - Attempted **ftp <IP>** and successfully logged in using the **anonymous** user.
 - Used **ls** to list files and **get flag.txt** to download the flag.



Practical Evidence





Phase 8: Metasploitable Pentesting & Windows Setup

Date: Feb 17, 2026

◆ Lab Penetration Testing (Metasploitable)

Continued penetration testing on the Metasploitable lab environment, focusing on remote access protocols.

Target: Metasploitable Linux VM. **Tools:** `msfconsole` (Metasploit Framework). **Protocols:** SSH (Port 22), Telnet (Port 23).

Exploitation Process:

- **Objective:** Perform dictionary attacks to gain credentials for remote access services.
- **Issue Encountered:** During the attack execution with `msfconsole`, the scanner failed to read the `user.txt` file correctly. The output showed: `[1] authentication failed " :<pass>"` instead of the expected format: `[1] authentication failed "<user>:<pass>"`
- **Troubleshooting & Fix:**
 - Analyzed the module configuration and input format.
 - **Solution:** Created a combined dictionary file named `userpass.txt` where usernames and passwords were separated by a space (format: `username password`).
 - **Result:** Re-running the attack with `userpass.txt` resolved the parsing error, allowing successful credential testing on both SSH and Telnet services.

◆ Windows Environment Setup

- **Objective:** Prepare a secure testing ground for advanced post-exploitation techniques.
- **Action:** Successfully installed **Windows 11 Enterprise** on VMware.
- **Future Plan:** This environment will be used to test credential dumping tools like **Mimikatz** in an upcoming session.



Phase 9: Post-Exploitation & Network Revision

Date: Feb 18, 2026

◆ Advanced Credential Dumping (Mimikatz)

Focused on privilege escalation and credential extraction on Windows environments.

Windows 11 Enterprise (Attempt):

- **Objective:** Extract credentials from memory using Mimikatz.
- **Challenges:** Encountered enhanced security protections (Credential Guard/LSA Protection) preventing access.
- **Troubleshooting Steps:**
 - Attempted to run via `nsexec` to gain SYSTEM privileges.
 - Modified Registry permissions via `regedit` to disable LSA protections.
- **Outcome:** Despite troubleshooting, modern Windows 11 defenses prevented successful extraction in the lab environment.

Windows 10 Enterprise (Success):

- **Action:** Migrated testing to a Windows 10 Enterprise VM.
- **Outcome:** Successfully executed Mimikatz commands (`privilege::debug`, `sekurlsa::logonpasswords`) to retrieve NTLM hashes and cleartext credentials.

◆ Network Security Revision

Revisited core networking concepts to solidify the theoretical foundation for advanced attacks.

- **Topics Reviewed:** OSI Model layers, common ports (21, 22, 80, 443, 445), and TCP/IP handshake.
- **Practical Exercise:** Conducted a Denial of Service (DoS) simulation using **hping3** to understand packet flooding mechanics (`hping3 -S --flood -V -p 80 <Target IP>`).

◆ Homework: TryHackMe Lab

- **Module:** Post-Exploitation Basics.
- **Key Learnings:** Enumeration after compromise, maintaining access, and dumping system hashes using tools like **Hashcat** and **John the Ripper**.

Technology Stack

- **OS:** Kali Linux, Ubuntu, Windows 10/11 Enterprise
- **Networking:** OSI Model, TCP/IP, IPv4/IPv6
- **Tools:** Nmap, Metasploit, Zphisher, MobSF, Nano, Apt, OpenVPN, Mimikatz, hping3
- **Virtualization:** VMware/VirtualBox (for Labs)

Future Scope

- Advanced Packet Analysis with **Wireshark**.
- Python scripting for automating penetration tests.
- Deep dive into Web Application Security (OWASP Top 10).

Internship Log maintained by Harmanjot Singh